THE BIG BANK ROBBERY

CROOKS DEFRAUDED BANKS OF Rs 1.38 LAKH CRORE IN 2020-21. SUCH STAGGERING SUMS SWINDLED FROM BANKS EVERY YEAR MOSTLY REMAIN UNRECOVERED. WORSE STILL, THE SCAMS ARE DETECTED MONTHS LATER AND ARRESTS LEAD TO FEW CONVICTIONS

By AMITABH SRIVASTAVA

JANARDAN SINGH SIGRIWAL, the BJP's Lok Sabha MP from Maharajganj in Bihar, was in for a shock in February 2021 when he realised that the Bank of Baroda's (BOB) branch in Chhapra, in Saran district, had suspended operations of his MPLADS (Members of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme) account. Sigriwal's aide rushed to the bank branch to enquire and returned with grim news. "The account had been put on hold. Fraudsters had withdrawn Rs 89 lakh from it using cloned cheques. These had been cleared by BOB's Ahmednagar branch (in Maharashtra) on November 3, 2020," says Sigriwal.

Sigriwal approached Union home minister Amit Shah, whose ministry flagged the matter at various levels for a thorough investigation, including by the Bihar government. BOB,



₹138,422 CRORE
Total funds swindled from banks in 2020-21

Illustration by RAJ VERMA